EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Is God in Heaven More Than Here?

Given Monday 8 July 2024 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 2:11

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 2, Chapter 11 (categories 3 to 8: feelings, relation, place, time, possession and position) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 8 July 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Ten Anthropomorphisms

The Rabbi planned to continue until the end of Essay 2, this week, next week and perhaps the week after, then break for August and resume in September.

Since Chapter 8, Rav Saadia has been working through the ways the Tanach describes HaKadosh Baruch Hu in physical terms. His general principle: we must always understand them **metaphorically**, because a literal reading goes against our intellect and against our tradition. He showed that **Targum Onkelos** and **Targum Yonatan ben Uziel** read such verses metaphorically, and that the Torah uses organs of nature too, as in **קפאו תהמת בלב ים**, "the depths congealed in the heart of the sea," where nobody thinks the sea has a heart.

Then came the ten categories:

#	Category	Covered
1	**Substance**	Impossible, since Hashem created all substance, and the verses show He is above every level of existence
2	**Quantity**	No length, height, size, division or multiplication. One commentator says Rav Saadia dwelt on this here because of the book **Shi'ur Komah**, which speaks of Hashem's "measurements"
	Prophecy	The **Kavod Nivra**, the created glory that Hashem reveals to the prophets

The created glory, once more

When the verse says **וירא אליו ה׳ באלני ממרא**, "Hashem appeared to him [Avraham] in the plains of Mamre," it is speaking *bederech chisaron*, with a word missing. It means the **Kavod** of Hashem was manifested with the three angels. "Chas veshalom, you can never see Hashem, because there's nothing there to see." The visions of Yechezkel and the chariot are of an image Hashem creates. As Richard said last week, it is all happening in the prophet's mind, but even in his mind he is not seeing God Himself. He is seeing the image God created there.

What then was special about Moshe? Rav Saadia does not use the idea of the *aspaklaria*, the mirrors. For him, Moshe's uniqueness, the principle that there is no prophet like Moshe, was that **Hashem spoke to him directly**, in his mind. With all other prophets it was the image, the intermediary angels, that spoke. And in all

prophecy the prophet knows for certain that he is in prophecy. "There's no such thing as doubtful prophecy. If you're a prophet, you know 100% this is the Kavod Hashem."

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3. Happenings and Feelings

The Rabbi noted that the word *mikrim* is usually translated "accidents," which is not quite right. It means **happenings**, and here mainly **feelings**. Hashem can have no happenings or changing circumstances, because He **created** all circumstances and happenings.

Verse	Meaning
כי ה׳ אהב משפט, "Hashem loves justice"; Hashem loves righteousness; **כי באלה חפצתי**, "for in these I delight" (Yirmiyahu 9:23)	Whatever Hashem **commanded** us to do is called "loved" by Him. He commands it strongly
שש הנה שנא ה׳, "six things Hashem hates" (Mishlei 6:16), and "all these I hate"	Whatever He commanded us **not** to do is called "hated"
רוצה ה׳ את יראיו, "Hashem desires those who fear Him"; **רצית ה׳ ארצך**, "You favoured Your land" (Tehillim 85:2)	When Hashem wants to **reward**, the Torah says He is pleased. "A perfect God cannot want"
וחרה אף ה׳ בכם ועצר את השמים, "Hashem's anger will flare and He will close the heavens" (from the Shema)	Anger means **punishment**. The verse itself shows it: the "anger" is the closing of the heavens

Real anger, will and hatred apply only to someone who wants and who is afraid. "How can Hashem want something if He's created all? How can He be afraid of something if He's created all?" So: if I want it, that is called "I love." If you do it and I am pleased with you, "I love you." If I do not want it, "I hate it." If you do it after I told you I hate it, "I am angry with you." "Simple as that."

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4. Relation

The fourth category is **relation**, in the sense of *yichus*, a relational standing between two things:

הללו עבדי ה׳, "Praise, servants of Hashem," as if Hashem has servants.

- Hashem as **King**, which requires subjects.

  משרתיו אש לוהט, "His ministers are a flaming fire" (Tehillim 104:4), the angels as His ministers.
- "Those who love Hashem" and "those who hate Hashem."

This is impossible, says Rav Saadia. **Hashem was there when none of these things existed.** Before He created anything, there was nothing to be King of, and yet He was God. He cannot now suddenly be in a relationship with what He created.

So why call Him King? To convey **grandeur**. For us, the greatest thing is a king, one who can do what he wants. But not a king in the sense that a king needs subjects and servants, "because He was that before." And "lovers of Hashem" simply means those who **do His will**.

Mark asked about **היום הרת עולם... אם כבנים אם כעבדים**, "if as children, if as servants," from Rosh Hashanah. That, said the Rabbi, is for us, to express our relationship with Hashem. But a father is incomplete without a son, and a king without subjects. You cannot describe Hashem like that, because it takes away from His completeness.

"We don't do anything for God"

Chaim drew the conclusion: God does not need any relationship with us. Everything we do, we do for ourselves. "God doesn't need anything from you. He was there and He will be there, with you or without you." The Rabbi agreed: "That's precisely what we're saying. It's very important. It's the core idea of Judaism." Even *leshem shamayim*, for the sake of heaven, does not mean we affect or influence God in any way. Chaim added that if you asked a thousand people, most would say they do mitzvot "for God." "That's why we're learning," said the Rabbi.

Flora asked: doesn't *mitzvah* come from the root meaning to **join**? So there must be some relationship, joining ourselves to Hashem.

The beam of light

The Rabbi answered with an analogy he loves:

Remember the opening of the old **Mr Bean** films? There's a beam of light, and he falls into it. That's Hashem, if you like. Mitzvah, *deveikut*, attaching ourselves, means **bringing yourself into that beam**. The light is there regardless of what you do, whether you choose to come or not, whether you exist or not, whether you do a mitzvah or an aveirah. That beam will always be there. That's God. There's no relation. If you want, you can bring yourself there.

The word *mitzvah* is connected to joining and cleaving. "You're bringing yourself nearer to that spotlight, and you're coming closer to God. But God's God, and God is there whether you like it or not, and whatever you do."

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5. Place

Then there are the verses that seem to give Hashem a **place**: **ושכנתי בתוכם**, "I will dwell among them," the Beit HaMikdash, and "Hashem is in heaven." Rav Saadia rejects this for three reasons:

1. **He created place.** How can He need it?
2. **He existed before there was any place.** If He did not need a place then, how can He need one now?
3. **Place belongs to physical things.** A place gives stability, a surrounding, a context. God needs no framework to ground Him.

What we were taught as children

"Ask any child," said the Rabbi, and this is the problem:

"We're taught things as children and we're never taught how to develop from that."

The Rambam already says that we teach children in stages: learn Torah and you get sweets; when you are a little older, learn Torah and you get money; and so on, until you learn for its own sake. "We develop our children and teenagers very much in their halachic skills, their reasoning skills, their analytical skills. But in their **theological** skills we remain with what we were taught as kids." You were taught that Hashem is in heaven, so if you want to daven, look up at the sky. "There's no such thing as Hashem in the sky. Hashem is everywhere."

Why "in heaven"?

So why does the Torah speak of Hashem in heaven, if He is no more there than here? The Rabbi explained: who do you look up to more, physically? A tall person more than a short one. Generally, taller people seem to

carry more gravitas. "We value things which are high. It's just something psychological in our brains." So to tell us how important Hashem is, the Torah speaks of Him being in heaven.

A participant suggested another angle: when these verses were written, the heavens were **unreachable**. That was the story of the Tower of Bavel: they thought they could build up to reach the unreachable. "Heaven" conveys separation: we are here, one kind of existence, and there is another beyond reach. "Nice. Very nice," said the Rabbi. "He doesn't say that, but that's interesting." The same applies to **אשא עיני אל ההרים**, "I lift my eyes to the mountains" (Tehillim 121:1): Hashem is not in the mountains.

"We forget it, but you have to realise this was groundbreaking for the time, 1,100 years ago." The Rabbi read from **Rav Moshe Taku**, the Tosafist from last week, who quotes Rav Saadia's *Sefer HaEmunot* on exactly this point, that when the prophets say Hashem is in heaven above it is only a way of glorifying Him, and responds with verses of his own, accusing Rav Saadia of arguing with the Torah. "So they understood, when it says Hashem is in heaven, Hashem is in heaven. It's fascinating, but that's how people believed."

Rav Saadia's two explanations

1. Saying Hashem is in a place is a way to **magnify that place**. God is not there any more than anywhere else.
2. "I will dwell among you" refers not to Hashem Himself but to the **Shechinah**, the created glory, just as with the prophets.

The Kotel: What Does Shechinah Mean?

This led to the longest discussion of the evening. What do we mean when we say it is more effective to pray at the Kotel?

Flora said the Shechinah was there; you feel His presence, the *kedushah* of the place. The Rabbi pressed her: "What does Shechinah mean?" To dwell. "Are you telling me God dwells in the Temple more than He dwells elsewhere?"

"Flora, let's get something very clear. The way you feel about something doesn't mean that it's true. That could purely be because you've been taught something. What you feel isn't a proof. I want you to explain to me rationally what it means that the Shechinah is there."

Marie suggested it is purely psychological. But the Torah does say there is a dwelling there. So, the Rabbi explained, there are two possibilities following Rav Saadia:

Explanation	Meaning
The created glory	Something really is there, but it is a **creation** of Hashem, not Hashem Himself. Just as He created an image for the prophets, this godliness rested in the Beit HaMikdash and was more perceptible there
An important place	Nothing is there that is not everywhere. "I dwell there" tells you this is an important place, as heaven is "important"

Mark offered a third idea: the place is holy because **mitzvot** were done there day in, day out, every moment, like "the lovers of Hashem" being those who constantly do His will. "Which is very nice," said the Rabbi, adding it to the list.

And the Rabbi was firm on the practical side:

"Chas veshalom to think that Hashem is there more than anywhere else. If we go to the Kotel and tell our kids, 'Hashem listens here better,' that's terrible. It's completely the wrong message to children."

Notes in the wall

Marie asked about the notes people place in the Kotel. The Rabbi said there is no source for it; it is a very new, modern practice. At best it helps you collect your thoughts. "But trust me, if you just pray the words, it's exactly the same." The problem is that people think Hashem picks up the note and listens to it more if it is in the wall, so they push it very high or very deep. "That's ridiculous. That's *kefirah*. That's all the wrong things put together." God cannot be in a stone.

Kissing the stones is fine, because it is the holiest place you can reach, whether because of the mitzvot done there or because the created *Kavod* of Hashem was there. And crying is fine, "because you want the Beit HaMikdash to be restored."

Flora said she does not put notes in the wall and can pray anywhere, "but I just feel there is something there." The Rabbi agreed: "It's a holy place, Flora, 100%. The Torah tells us the Shechinah was there." The question is whether a person feels it because of the real *kedushah*, "which I imagine is the case with you," or because he has been told it is holy and makes himself feel it.

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6. Time

Hashem has no time, for three reasons:

1. **He created time**, as we learned in Essay 1.
2. **He existed before there was time.** If so, He cannot become subject to it once it exists.
3. **Time measures physical things.** What is not physical is above time.

Rav Saadia brings three verses that seem to put Hashem in time, "some more difficult than others":

Verse	Problem	Rav Saadia	Ibn Ezra
ומעולם עד עולם אתה אל, "from everlasting to everlasting You are God" (Tehillim 90:2)	Seems to place Him in time	Through all eternity **Your actions** have been to help us. "Pretty straightforward"	
לפני לא נוצר אל ואחרי לא יהיה, "before Me no god was formed, and after Me there will be none" (Yeshayahu 43:10)	What is "before God"? A past, present and future? "We say it, we don't think about it"	Not before *Me*, but before **My actions**: before and after I sent the prophet, I am the same God. The passage is about His prophet	Before I was **revealed** to the people, and after
גם מיום אני הוא, "also from the day, I am He" (Yeshayahu 43:13)	From that day He is God, and not before?	From the day of the **Revelation** at Sinai, I am the One commanding you	From when there was a **day** at all, the first day of creation: I have always been there

For "after Me" meaning "after My actions," Rav Saadia brings Natan the prophet's words to Batsheva, **ואני אבוא אחריך ומלאתי את דבריך**, "and I will come in after you and confirm your words" (Melachim I 1:14): after your action, not following your person.

On the third verse, the Rabbi commented: "Quite a lot of additions to the verse, according to Rav Saadia. Not the smoothest. Ibn Ezra has a much simpler explanation." But both are trying to escape the same problem: implying a time limitation on God, which is unacceptable.

Does interacting with us put Hashem in time?

Two participants pressed the point. The Torah describes Hashem acting causally and in sequence: He speaks with Moshe after something happens, He "is comforted," He changes His mind. Doesn't that put Him in time?

The Rabbi's answer: "If He's going to interact with humans, He has to play ball with human time." That is not a limitation on Him. "From us there has been a change. This was ten minutes ago and this is now, because we live in time. From Hashem's perspective there is no 'was'. It's all happening in one go. I know it's hard for us to understand what that means, but we have to accept it." He compared it to the Rambam on free will, which they had learned in Pirkei Avot and the Shemoneh Perakim. Moshe was on the mountain for forty days, "but that's all from Moshe's side, for the people downstairs. In God's perspective there's no forty days." ("Is God comforted, does He change His mind" is a separate question about emotion, already covered.)

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7. Possession

Hashem owns everything. So what does it mean when the Torah calls us His:

עם סגולה, His treasured people,

- His possession, **חבל נחלתו**, the lot of His inheritance,

כי חלק ה׳ עמו, "Hashem's portion is His people"?

Are we His more than a non-Jew is? No. It is to show **importance**. Among humans, your treasure chest is where you keep the best things. "You are My treasure" means "you are very important to Me."

It works the other way too. The pious speak of Hashem as **their** portion: **ה׳ מנת חלקי**, "Hashem is my portion" (Tehillim 16:5). And "the God of Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov" or "the God of the Hebrews" does not exclude anyone else. He is the God of all, but this expresses importance, treasure and love for His pious ones.

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8. Position: Standing and Sitting

God is not physical, so He has no position: no sitting, no standing, no going up or down.

- Only physical things sit or stand.
- He existed before these things existed.
- A position is a relation between two things: you sit on a chair, you stand on a floor.
- It would introduce **diversity and change**, and we learned at length earlier in the essay that there is no change in Hashem.

Verse	Meaning
וישב ה׳ מלך לעולם, "Hashem sat as King forever"" (Tehillim 29:10)	He is **permanent and enduring**, like someone who sits in his place forever
קומה ה׳, "Arise, Hashem," and smite Your enemies"	Act **quickly**. Deal with the enemies quickly
ויתיצב עמו שם, Hashem "stood with him there," at the Thirteen Attributes (Shemot 34:5)	"This is more difficult." It is stated so plainly that Rav Saadia says it refers to the **Shechinah**, the created image, which stood there
וילך ה׳ כאשר כלה לדבר אל אברהם, "Hashem went," when He finished speaking to Avraham" (Bereishit 18:33)	Again the created light

"So it's interesting," the Rabbi noted. "Sometimes Saadia is happy to say it's a metaphor. But other times he says, actually, it's literal, but it's not God. It's the Shechinah which He has created."

Summary

1. **Feelings:** Hashem's "love" means His command to do, "hate" His command not to do, "desire" His reward and "anger" His punishment. Only one who wants and fears has real feelings.
2. **Relation:** Hashem was God before there was anything to be King of. "King," "servants" and "Father" are for us, to express importance. **We do nothing for Hashem**; mitzvot bring *us* into the beam of light that is always there.
3. **Place:** He created place and existed before it. "In heaven" conveys importance, or the unreachable. "I will dwell among them" means either an important place or the created *Shechinah*. Never teach children that Hashem listens better at the Kotel.
4. **Time:** He created time and preceded it. Verses about "before Me" and "from that day" refer to His actions or to the Revelation (Rav Saadia), or more simply to His revelation and eternity (Ibn Ezra). He enters our time only because we live in it.
5. **Possession:** He owns everything. "Treasured people" expresses love and importance.
6. **Position:** He neither sits nor stands. "Sat as King" means permanence and "Arise" means speed. Where the verse is too plain ("He stood with him there"), it is the created Shechinah.

Coming Up

- **Next Monday:** Chapter 12, categories 9 and 10, **actions** of Hashem and Hashem as the **recipient** of action, including the episode in Ki Tisa of "you will see My back, but My face shall not be seen."
- Then Chapter 13, a few final questions, and a review of the whole essay the following Monday.

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